Had they learnt lessons from the history of other insurgent and terrorist groups and devised their strategies accordingly to avoid annihilation? There was every possibility of this angle because circumstantial evidence showed that TTP and Al Qaeda ideologues carried out research and engaged into discussions with various well-informed quarters to devise their strategies and tactics. Some splintering could be a strategic move emulating Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia's (FARC) 'Plan Rebirth', which it devised in 2008 after realising that it could not succeed in direct confrontations with Colombian security forces. According to this plan, the group retreated to its traditional strongholds, decentralised its leadership and formed into smaller units. It also changed tactics accordingly, relying more on hit-and-run ambushes, improvised explosive devices and small, mobile sniper teams that allowed the guerrillas to strike government forces without engaging them directly in conventional combat (Colby, 2012).

In a similar fashion, the Swati TTP had escaped from Swat in the wake of Operation 'Rah-e-Rast' and started fighting back from across the border. Afghan Taliban had made a strategic retreat from Kabul and other cities after the US attack on Afghanistan and started fighting back, which has continued for years. Strategising under pressure has a cost. TTP's fragmentation might be its strategy to confuse the army. But the general impression was that it created a dent in its organisational setup and command structure. This impression led many to believe that it was the beginning of the end of TTP and that terrorism might come to an end in a couple of years or so. It is highly unlikely. Rather the scenario seemed the opposite.

The year 2012 started with renewed contact and relationships between Al Qaeda, Afghan Taliban and TTP. The TTP spokesperson Ehsanullah Ehsan told the Associated Press that in November and December 2011, meetings were held between the leaders of the trio, in which the senior Al Qaeda commander Abu Yahya al-Libi asked the TTP leader Hakimullah Mehsud to end their in-fights and give manpower to the Afghan Taliban and Al Qaeda in Afghanistan to put up resistance against the American and international forces (*The Daily Times*, 2012). A pamphlet was distributed in North Waziristan stating that a five-member committee known as *Shura-e-Muraqaba* was established in consultation with the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan. It called on